

1, Religion Played a Crucial, Positive Role in Human History, Especially in Early Feudal Society

Over the past six months, if you asked me which concept I have experienced the most drastic paradigm shift regarding, it would undoubtedly be religion.

In China's official propaganda, although religion might not be explicitly denounced on the surface, people can distinctly sense that religion occupies the role of the antagonist in China's historical and political narratives. The government tirelessly propagandizes to the people: *If religion lacks the leadership of the Party, it bears no essential difference from an evil cult.*

Growing up in such a public opinion environment, even if people do not actively despise religion, they absolutely lack any genuine understanding of it—because there are simply no opportunities to understand it.

For myself, I must admit that even up until age 22, I held an overwhelmingly negative attitude toward religion. Yet today, my stance is positive. This is primarily because I have realized a kind of "**universal rationality**" (普遍的合理性)—meaning that when a social phenomenon appears universally across the globe, the factors driving its emergence absolutely cannot be isolated, regional, or accidental.

Take, for instance, the Eurasian Great Migration during the **feudalization** period that I mentioned earlier. This historical event, which occurred universally across a region spanning nearly ten thousand kilometers from east to west across the Eurasian continent, had a projection in China that we refer to as the *Uprising of the Five Barbarians* (五胡乱华).

In our country's prevailing historical narrative, the cause of the *Uprising of the Five Barbarians* is overwhelmingly attributed to the incompetence of the Sima clan (司马氏). A slightly more materialist explanation might specifically point to imperial clan policies or the rise of the **aristocratic great clans** (门阀士族). Meanwhile, the idealist explanation outright attributes it to the karmic retribution brought upon the Sima family for their treacherous, flip-flopping actions when usurping the Cao Wei regime.

To anyone educated in modern science, this viewpoint is so absurd that it is essentially "**not even wrong**"—yet astonishingly, it commands such a massive market in China!

The most ridiculous part is that you almost never see Chinese people pondering this simple question: *If karmic retribution truly exists, why did it only fall upon the head of the Sima family? Among the monarchs and bureaucrats of the Chinese Empire, how many did NOT deserve karmic retribution?*

From that moment, I could clearly recognize that a universally occurring historical event across the globe (like the Great Migration) simply cannot be explained merely by the moral failings of a few individuals. For example, I can now clearly point out that the various phenomena during the Western Jin Dynasty—whether the inward migration of ethnic minorities, the granting of immense power to imperial princes, or the increasingly prominent role played by the **aristocratic great clans** in politics—were essentially just the diverse societal impacts produced by the development of the **feudalization** process. As for the actual political or moral caliber of the Sima rulers, in the long run, it exerted no substantial impact on the historical trajectory of the late Jin period.

Therefore, when I reconsidered religion, I discovered that since world religions spread universally during the early stages of **feudalization** in various regions, and almost every region's **feudalization**

across the globe had to bind itself to a religion, the force supporting the birth and spread of religion—compelling the masses to convert—must have been a universal social necessity shared by the entire world.

Under these circumstances, the simplistic assertion that *"religion is the opium of the people"* is far too arbitrary and dogmatic.

Narcotics indeed cause addiction and inflict immense harm upon the human body, but they are fundamentally something you can live a perfectly normal life without. Can something upon which a person relies for survival truly be considered a narcotic?

Just as in the modern world, almost all living organisms (except for certain microorganisms) universally require oxygen to survive; yet, oxidation does indeed cause living bodies to continuously age. If someone were to claim: *"Oxygen is a slow-acting poison that eventually causes human death over 70 to 100 years,"* would this statement not be utterly bizarre?

It is true that in modern society, religion no longer plays the critical role of holding the social structure together. Citizens of modern societies can live perfectly well relying on adequate scientific literacy without depending on any religion. However, these modern facts cannot negate the colossal role religion once played during historical periods.

Religion was born from humanity's contemplation of the inevitable questions encountered in life. Most of these questions possess universality—such as life and death—while the rest are at least communally faced within a specific regional environment. This is precisely why religions hold the potential to be widely believed.

What is truly extraordinary is that in antiquity—especially during the early era of **feudalization** when the communities upon which people relied for survival had regressed to their smallest units—religion and religious organizations played the crucial role of maintaining circulation beyond mere economic demands, as well as sustaining technological investment and requirements.

Devotees endure unimaginable hardships to make pilgrimages to holy lands not for economic gain. Mendicant preachers travel tens of thousands of miles to foreign lands to propagate the faith, bringing with them far more than just the religion itself. Believers and religious institutions offer relief to the destitute, knowing full well it is difficult to reap any economic return.

To spread religious thought, people in backward regions attempt to comprehend, and even invent, their own written scripts. To construct magnificent religious edifices, religious organizations demand the most advanced—even entirely new—engineering and mathematics. To defend their sects in debates, people rigorously study logic and rhetoric.

(Of course, we must not forget the point mentioned in the previous section regarding religious support for massive water conservancy projects).

Even setting aside religion's role in constructing medieval society, it essentially functioned as a **"safety net"** (兜底) for human society. That is to say, it ensured that even in a **feudal society** where **social surplus** (社会剩余) was relatively low and connections between regions were fragile, the social surplus could still achieve a certain degree of integration. It ensured that social contradictions would not become overly intensified, and that technological progress and dissemination could maintain a certain scale. Viewed across the entirety of human history, this function has been exceptionally colossal!

When the society of the early **feudalization** period collapsed into myriad micro-communities due to shifts in the **economic base**, people utilized *ideas*—rather than visible, predictable immediate interests—to forge a vastly larger community. This transcendental community exceeded the land a person could measure with their feet, surpassed the territory a nation could rule, and shattered the boundaries that political power could reach.

Religion acted as a brake, halting the continued disintegration of the social structure, and provided vital spiritual support for people terrified and unnerved amid catastrophic upheaval.

When reading Japanese history previously, I felt this latter point particularly profoundly. For two centuries, intellectuals of the late Heian period clearly sensed that the **feudalization** process was disintegrating the original dynastic state. They had no idea where the path forward lay; fear and profound disorientation popularized the notion that Japan was on the verge of—or had already entered—the *Mappō* (Latter Day of the Law / 末法时代).

During the tumultuous years surrounding the Genpei War (源平合戦), the entire archipelago society was battered by the chaos of war, and ordinary commoners began to grow deeply anxious. In an era that could be described as arduous for all strata of Japan, Buddhism played a bedrock role in inspiring people to regain their confidence.

Whether it was through massive engineering projects like the reconstruction of Tōdai-ji (东大寺), or the fact that the founders of Kamakura Buddhism ceased viewing the "spiritual protection of the state for the rulers" (镇护国家) as their sole enterprise and turned their focus instead toward the spiritual world of the myriad commoners—it all helped people survive those grueling times. Ultimately, this forged the *Giri* (duty and obligation / 义理) of Japanese **feudal society**, with Buddhism and Shintoism as its cornerstones.

The reason such a monumental achievement is easily overlooked is precisely because, in the past, people were unaccustomed to utilizing comparative history on a global scale.

As long as one contrasts the medieval societies of Europe and Japan with the society of China's **restoration-bureaucratic period**, the success and failure become glaringly obvious.

In our country, it is virtually impossible for the surplus of social production to be used to expand production or make investments; it is entirely consumed by the bureaucratic system. The people are stripped of the capacity to organize at the grassroots level, and the court intentionally sabotages any potential for such unity. Spiritually, the entire nation has already collapsed—a point that needs no explanation, and defies explanation; anyone who has personally experienced it naturally knows.

If one has not lived in Chinese society for a prolonged period, it is absolutely impossible for them to grasp, through mere imagination, just how profoundly evil human beings can become.

There is an excellent, famous saying on the Chinese internet: *What the Chinese are most adept at is judging exactly who is weak and can be bullied with impunity, and exactly who cannot be bullied, before whom they can only kneel and endure being bullied.*

Over the past six months, I have gradually come to realize one thing: **virtually everything that a restoration-bureaucratic state fears and suppresses is precisely what is genuinely beneficial to the people.**

Because any action that allows grassroots power to expand—whether materially, organizationally, or spiritually—will inevitably weaken the bureaucratic state, which is essentially a "prison of nations" (各民族监狱).

Therefore, when the bureaucratic state was restored in China from the Sui and Tang Dynasties onward, it was perfectly normal for various religions led by Buddhism—including Christianity introduced after contact with the West—to be treated with intense hostility in China.

People must consider what religion once meant to us from the perspective of the existence of an **"alternative possibility."** What has occurred in our country has proven that human beings are exactly this kind of animal: clever enough to possess the power to destroy themselves, yet foolish enough to lack the capacity to reliably control this power.

Suppose that, around the beginning of **feudalization**, human society had never witnessed the emergence of world religions that spread so widely in actual history. *(I wish to point out here that although Buddhism was born far prior to feudalization, the Buddhism that truly adapted to the feudalization process emerged precisely to meet the demands of the times. Just as no one would argue that the Heian Buddhism aimed at magically protecting the state is the same as the Zen Buddhism worshipped by the medieval samurai—not to mention the drastic changes in religious doctrine [宗教教义], even the very purpose of the religion had become radically different).*

Under such an assumption, humanity would highly likely have stagnated in agricultural society for a much longer period, which inherently introduces massive uncertainty.

Consider merely this one point: if humanity had perpetually been unable to utilize fossil fuels, then whether it be deforestation or land reclamation, the ultimate limits would eventually be reached, and ecological collapse would be an unavoidable inevitability.

In that scenario, let alone whether humanity would have any chance to enter modern civilization, merely maintaining the status quo without regressing would already be a miracle.

Yet, as we now know, the greatness of humanity lies in the fact that, while using our minds to answer the practical concerns of reality, we transcended the limitations of predictable, immediate calculations of self-interest, ensuring that we did not stagnate in the **feudal period** for too long.

Therefore, the rise of religion in the **Middle Ages** (中世宗教) is indeed the most powerful proof of the magnitude of human subjective initiative (主观能动性).

As a materialist, or an atheist who believes in modern science, one should not—and has absolutely no need to—deny the monumental contributions religion made to the peace and stability of the realm. A **religious doctrine** (宗教教义) might be idealist (唯心的) and unscientific, but the history of the formation and development of the religion itself is precisely materialist (唯物物的) and entirely conforms to the theories of social science.

True strength lies not in "me standing in opposition to you," but in "you being encompassed by me."

If we study religion from a scientific perspective, acknowledging religion's contributions will not diminish the mighty power of science in the slightest, because the former can itself be fully explained by science.

However, I must admit that my observations of religion are exceedingly superficial. Because in my current environment, I lack both the conditions for intuitive perception and the access to highly valuable literature and historical documents.

Chinese culture inherently lacks philosophical speculation (哲学思辨), and despotic rulers throughout history have naturally never wanted the commoners to be exposed to such things. Consequently, I can say I know next to nothing about specific religious philosophy.

Although I know many questions are of monumental significance, I simply have no starting point to research them.

For example, what common characteristics did the medieval religions (including Christianity, Islam, Buddhism, and Hinduism) popular during the early **feudalization** period share in terms of **religious doctrines** (教义), **religious orders** (教团), propagation models, and their interactive dynamics with secular regimes? And how did they differ from the state religions prior to **feudalization** (*i.e.*, *Classical religions*)?

Or, for instance, how did the doctrines of various religions transform throughout the entire **feudalization** process? Through what methods did the major religions enact these transformations? How did heretical sects (异端派别) emerge, and what social phenomena did they reflect? How did the major religions cope with mystic schools (神秘主义流派)?

If these questions could be answered thoroughly, it would be of immense help for humanity to understand the medieval feudal class society (中世封建阶级社会)—the most crucial historical period since the birth of humanity—and thereby grasp the developmental trajectory of human civilization.

If these thoughts I have written can one day be seen by others, I sincerely hope that someone with a profound understanding of religion and its history—especially of Christianity—can step forward and provide scientific, persuasive answers!

1, 宗教在人类历史上, 特别是封建社会早期发挥了重要的, 正面的作用

在过去六个月里, 如果我说对于哪个概念有着最大幅度的改观, 那非宗教莫属。在中国的官方宣传里虽然不会明面上加以贬斥, 但是人们可以明显地感觉到宗教在中国的历史和政治叙事中处于反派角色的位置, 政府不厌其烦地对人民宣传道: 如果宗教没有了党的领导, 那么它跟邪教也没有本质区别。在这种舆论环境下长大的人们, 即使不说多厌恶宗教, 但是绝对对宗教是没有什么了解的, 因为也没有什么机会可以了解。对我个人而言, 我必须承认, 即使在 22 年前我对于宗教总体而言还是持负面态度, 但是现在我对它持正面态度。这首先是因为我意识到了一种“普遍的合理性”, 也就是当一种社会现象在世界范围内普遍出现的时候, 使它产生的因素必然不会是个别性的, 地域性的和偶然性的。

就如同我之前所说的封建化时期的欧亚民族大迁徙问题, 这个在横跨了欧亚大陆东西近万公里的地地区普遍发生的历史事件在中国的投影被我们称为五胡乱华。在我国的普遍历史叙事中, 五胡乱华发生的原因被极大地归咎为司马氏的无能, 稍微讲一点唯物主义的說法会具体解释为民族政策, 宗室政策或者门阀士族兴起, 而唯心主义的說法干脆把这归咎于司马家当年夺取曹魏政权时出尔反尔的举措带来的报应。这种在任何受过现代科学教育的人看来都离谱到“**not even wrong**”的观点, 居然在中国有如此广泛的市场。最可笑的是你几乎看不到中国人去思考这么一个问题, 如果因果报应真的存在那么它为什么只落到司马家头上, 中华帝国的君主和官僚有几个不应该得到报应的? 从那个时候开始我就可以很清楚地认识到, 对于(如民族大迁徙)这样一个世界范围内普遍发生的历史事件, 就不可能仅以个别人在道德层面上的问题加以解释。例如现在我已经可以清晰地指出, 西晋年间的各种现象, 无论是少数民族内迁也好, 还是宗室藩王被赋予极大权力, 还是门阀士族在政治中扮演越来越重要的作用, 这本质上都是封建化进程发展在社会不同方面产生的影响罢了。至于司马氏的统治者本人的政治水平如何, 道德水平如何, 从长远看, 没有在晋末的历史进程中发挥任何可观的作用。

因此当我重新考虑宗教的时候，我发现既然世界性宗教于各地的封建化早期得到了普遍传播，几乎全世界每个地方的封建化都要和一种宗教进行绑定，那么支持宗教诞生并传播，使得人民皈依宗教的就必然是全世界共同存在的普遍的社会需求。在这种情况下，简简单单说“宗教是人民的鸦片”未免就太过武断了。毒品确实使人上瘾，而且对人身有极大危害，但是他必然是一种即使你不接触也不影响正常生活的东西。一个人赖以生存的东西难道能够算毒品吗？就像现在全世界的除了微生物以外的几乎全部生物普遍都需要氧气存活，但是氧化作用确实会使得生命体不断衰老。那么如果一个人说：氧气是使人在 70 到 100 年间最终死亡的慢性毒品，这个说法是否太过怪异了。宗教在现代社会确实已经不再扮演维系社会结构这样重要的角色，现代社会的公民完全可以不依赖于任何宗教而凭借合格的科学素养进行生活，但是这些事实不能否认宗教在历史时期曾经起到的巨大作用。

宗教诞生于人对于生活中所必然要面对的一些问题的思考，这些问题大多具有普世性，例如生和死，其余问题至少是一个区域环境内所共同遇到的，所以宗教才有了被广泛信仰的可能。真正非凡的事在于，在古代特别是人们维持生活所依赖的共同体退化到最小的封建化时代早期，宗教和宗教组织起到了维持超越经济需求的流通以及技术投资和技术需求的作用。教徒不辞劳苦前往圣地朝圣，并非为了经济利益。托钵宣道者不远万里前往异国弘法，带来的不只是宗教本身。教徒和宗教场所接济赤贫的百姓，难以获得经济回报。为了传播宗教思想，落后地区的人们尝试认识，甚至创造自己的文字。为了建设宏伟的宗教场所，宗教组织需要最先进的，乃至新的工程学和数学。为了在辩论中维护自己的教派，人们刻苦钻研逻辑与修辞。当然不要忘了上一部分已经提到过的宗教对于大型水利工程的支持。即使抛开宗教对于中世纪社会的构建作用，它还产生了一种为人类社会“兜底”的功能，也就是确保了即使是在社会剩余比较少，各地区之间联系微弱的封建阶级社会中社会剩余仍能得到一定程度的整合，社会矛盾不至于过于激化，技术的进步和传播仍能维持一定规模，这一作用在人类的整个历史来看特别巨大。当封建化早期的社会因为经济基础变化而瓦解为一个个小共同体，人们用思想，而不是眼前可见的，可预测的利益，创造了更为广大的共同体，它超过了一个人能用脚步丈量的土地，一个民族所能统治的疆域，突破了政治权力所能延伸到的边界。宗教起到了遏制社会结构继续解体的作用，为剧变中惶恐不安的人们提供了精神上的支持。

我之前在读日本史的时候对后一点尤为感慨，平安晚期的知识分子在两个世纪里清晰地感受到封建化进程正在瓦解掉原有的王朝国家，他们不知道前路在何处，恐惧和迷茫让日本即将进入已经进入末法时代这样的说法变得流行。在源平合战前后的动荡岁月里，整个列岛社会受到战乱的冲击，普通民众也开始不安起来。在这样一个对于日本的所有阶层都堪称艰难的年代，佛教对于鼓舞人们重拾信心起到了中流砥柱的作用，无论是重建东大寺这样的大型工程，还是镰仓佛教的创始人们不再以为统治者镇护国家为唯一的事业转而去关注天下万民的精神世界，都帮助人们度过了那些艰难的时日，并且最终形成了以佛教和神道为基石的日本封建社会的义理。

这样的鸿业之所以容易被人们忽视，原因正是过去人们还不习惯在全世界范围内利用比较历史学。只要把欧洲和日本的中世纪社会与中国官僚复辟时期的社会相对比则成败再显见不过，在我国，社会生产剩余几乎难以被用来扩大生产或进行投资，而完全被官僚系统所消耗；人民缺乏基层组织的能力，而朝廷也有意的破坏这种可能的联合；从精神上看整个国家已经崩溃了，这一点无需解释，也无法解释，亲身经历过的人自然知道。谁若是没有在中国社会长久生活，他绝对无法凭借想象力就能猜到人究竟可以邪恶到什么程度。中文互联网上有一句名言说得很好，中国人最擅长的事情，就是判断什么人好欺负也可以随便欺负，而什么人不能欺负见了只能跪下被欺负。在过去半年里，我逐渐意识到了一点，凡是复辟官僚国家所恐惧打压的，几乎都是真正对于人民有所益的事物，因为任何使得基层力量得以扩大的行为，无论是物质上，组织上还是精神上，都会削弱官僚国家这个各民族监狱。因此当官僚国家自隋唐以来在中国复辟，以佛教为首的各种宗教，包括与西方接触之后传来的基督教在中国被敌视实在是再正常不过了。人们必须从“另一种可能性”的存在这个角度来考虑宗教到底曾经对于我们意味着什么，我国发生的事情已经证明，人类就是这样一种动物，他们聪明到拥有可以毁灭自己的力量，同时又愚蠢到没有能力可靠的控制这种力量。假使在封建化开始前后人类社会不曾出现过现实历史中传播如此广泛的世界性宗教（这里想指出的是，佛教诞生的时候固然离封建化很远，但是真正适应封建化进程的佛教应时而生的。就跟没有人会认为日本平安时期以法术镇护国家的佛教和中世武士所信仰的禅宗是一回事，不要说教义发生了很大变化，即使是宗教的目的也已经截然不同了），人类很可能在农业社会停留得更久，这本身就造成一种不确定性。

仅仅考虑这么一点，如果人类一直无法利用化石燃料，那么无论是林木砍伐还是土地开垦早晚都会到达极限，生态崩溃是没有办法避免的事情。这样的话，不要说人类是否还有机会进入现代文明，想要保持不倒退就已经是奇迹了。然而现在我们知道，人类的伟大之处在于人在用自己的思想去解答现实关切的同时，超越了可预测的现实利益考量的局限性，使得自己没有封建时期停留太久。因而，中世宗教的兴起的确是人类主观能动性能够起到多大作用最有力的证明。作为唯物主义者或者相信现代科学的无神论者，就更不应该也更没有必要去否认宗教曾为天下太平所立下的功勋，宗教的教义或许是唯心的、不科学的，但是宗教本身形成和发展的历史恰恰是唯物的，合乎社会科学理论的。真正的强大不是我与你对立，而是你被我包含，如果我们从科学的角度去研究宗教，那么承认宗教的贡献半点不会有损科学的伟力，因为前者本身就是可以被科学解释的。

但是我必须承认，我对于宗教的观察实在是极其浅显，因为在我现处的环境中既缺乏能够直观感受的条件，又极难得到具有价值的文献资料。中国文化本身缺乏哲学思辨，历代统治者当然也不希望老百姓接触这些，因此我对于具体的宗教哲学就可以说是一无所知。虽然有很多问题我知道其具有重大意义，但是要想研究却也无从下手，比如封建化早期所流行的中世宗教包括基督教，伊斯兰教，佛教，印度教在教义，教团组织，传播模式和与世俗政权如何进行互动等方面存在什么共同特征，又与封建化之前的国家宗教有何种区别？又比如在整个封建化进程中各宗教的教义发生了何种改变？各大宗教以何种方式去做出这一改变？异端派别是怎样产生的并反映了何种社会现象？各大宗教如何应对神秘主义流派？这些问题如果能够得到很好的回答，对于人类理解中世封建阶级社会这一自人类诞生以来最重要的历史时期进而把握人类文明的发展进程极有帮助。如果我写的这些想法有朝一日能够被人看见，希望对宗教及其历史有所了解，特别是对基督教有所了解的人能够给出科学的有说服力的回答吧！